📚 STUDENT WORKBOOK · TERM ___

SWIM & WATER SAFETY

Health & Physical Education · Year 7–8 · Victorian Secondary School

STUDENT NAME	CLASS / GROUP	TEACHER
_____	_____	_____

Curriculum: Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0 VC2HP8P10 VC2HP8P10 VC2HP8M01

Strand: Personal, Social & Community Health – Health Education

Focus Areas: Safety (S) · LPA · FMS

Welcome to your Swim & Water Safety Workbook! Victoria has some of the most beautiful beaches, rivers, lakes and pools in Australia — and some of the most dangerous conditions. This workbook will help you build the knowledge, skills and confidence to keep yourself and others safe in and around water. Complete all activities thoughtfully and honestly.

1 Why Water Safety Matters in Victoria

📖 KEY KNOWLEDGE

- 52 fatal drownings occurred in Victoria in 2024–25
- About 1 in 8 victims were aged 15–24 years old

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- Males are 4× more likely to drown than females
- Inland waterways (rivers, dams) are especially dangerous
- Non-fatal drownings were 60% above the 10-year average
- Zero deaths in public swimming pools — but 25% were in home environments
- Cold water shock can affect even strong swimmers
- Alcohol is a factor in many adult drowning deaths

💬 Activity 1.1 — Personal Connection

Individual · ~5 min

Think about your own experiences near or in water. Answer the following questions honestly.

WHAT IS YOUR FAVOURITE WATER ENVIRONMENT? (TICK ONE)

- ☐ 🏖 Beach (patrolled)
- ☐ 🌊 Beach (unpatrolled)
- ☐ 🏊 Pool (public/school)
- ☐ 🏡 Pool (private/backyard)
- ☐ 🏞 River / dam / lake
- ☐ ❌ I avoid water

HOW WOULD YOU RATE YOUR SWIMMING ABILITY?

- ◯ Non-swimmer / still learning
- ◯ Can swim short distances
- ◯ Comfortable swimmer
- ◯ Strong / confident swimmer

📊 Activity 1.2 — Data Analysis

Individual · ~10 min

Study the Victorian drowning statistics from the Life Saving Victoria 2024–25 Drowning Report. Use the data to answer the questions below.

Category	2023–24 Data	What does this tell us?
Total fatal drownings	**52 deaths**	*Write your interpretation here...*
Young people (15–24 yrs)	**About 1 in 8 victims**	*Write your interpretation here...*
Gender	**38 of 52 were male**	*Write your interpretation here...*
Location	**All at unpatrolled sites**	*Write your interpretation here...*

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2 MARKS

QUESTION 1.2A

Using the data above, explain TWO reasons why teenagers and young people in Victoria face a higher risk of drowning.

1. _____

_____

2. _____

_____

2 MARKS

QUESTION 1.2B

The data shows ALL drowning deaths in 2024–25 occurred at *unpatrolled* locations. What does this suggest about the importance of swimming at patrolled beaches and pools?

_____

_____

_____

2 Beach Flags, Signals & Safe Swimming

📖 KEY KNOWLEDGE — BEACH FLAG SYSTEM (AUSTRALIA)

- **Red & Yellow flags** = patrolled swimming area — ALWAYS swim here
- **Black & white quartered** = surfers/watercraft zone — not for swimmers
- **Orange windsock** = offshore winds, no inflatables
- **Single red flag** = dangerous conditions, swim with extreme caution
- **Yellow + black ball** = swimming only, no surfboards
- **Purple flag** = dangerous marine life present

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- Lifeguards are trained professionals — always follow their instructions
- The BeachSafe app (beachsafe.org.au) shows patrolled beaches near you

Activity 2.1 — Flag Identification

Individual · ~8 min

Below are six beach flag diagrams. Write the correct name and meaning of each flag in the boxes provided.



Flag 1: _____

Meaning: _____

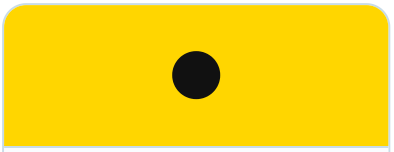


Flag 2: _____

Meaning: _____

Flag 3: _____

Meaning: _____



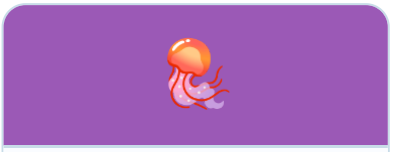
Flag 4: _____

Meaning: _____



Flag 5: _____

Meaning: _____



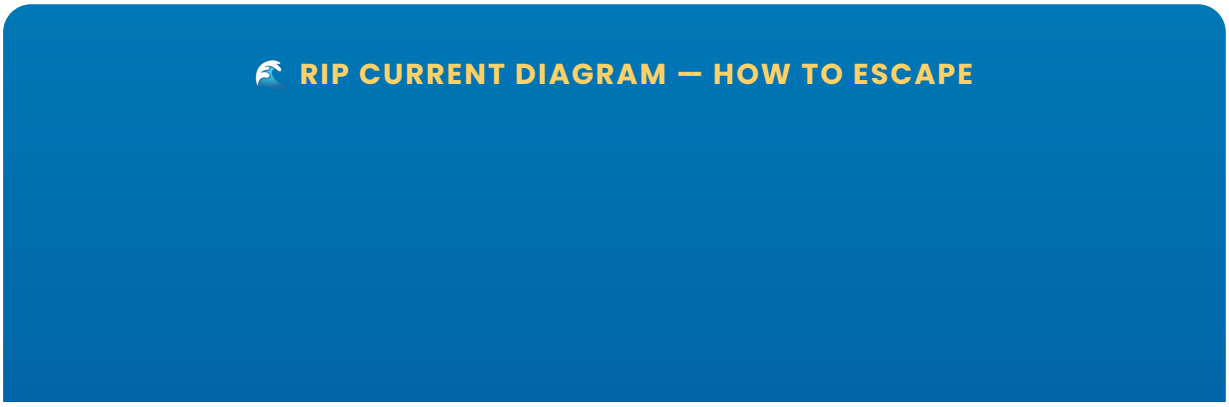
Flag 6: _____

Meaning: _____

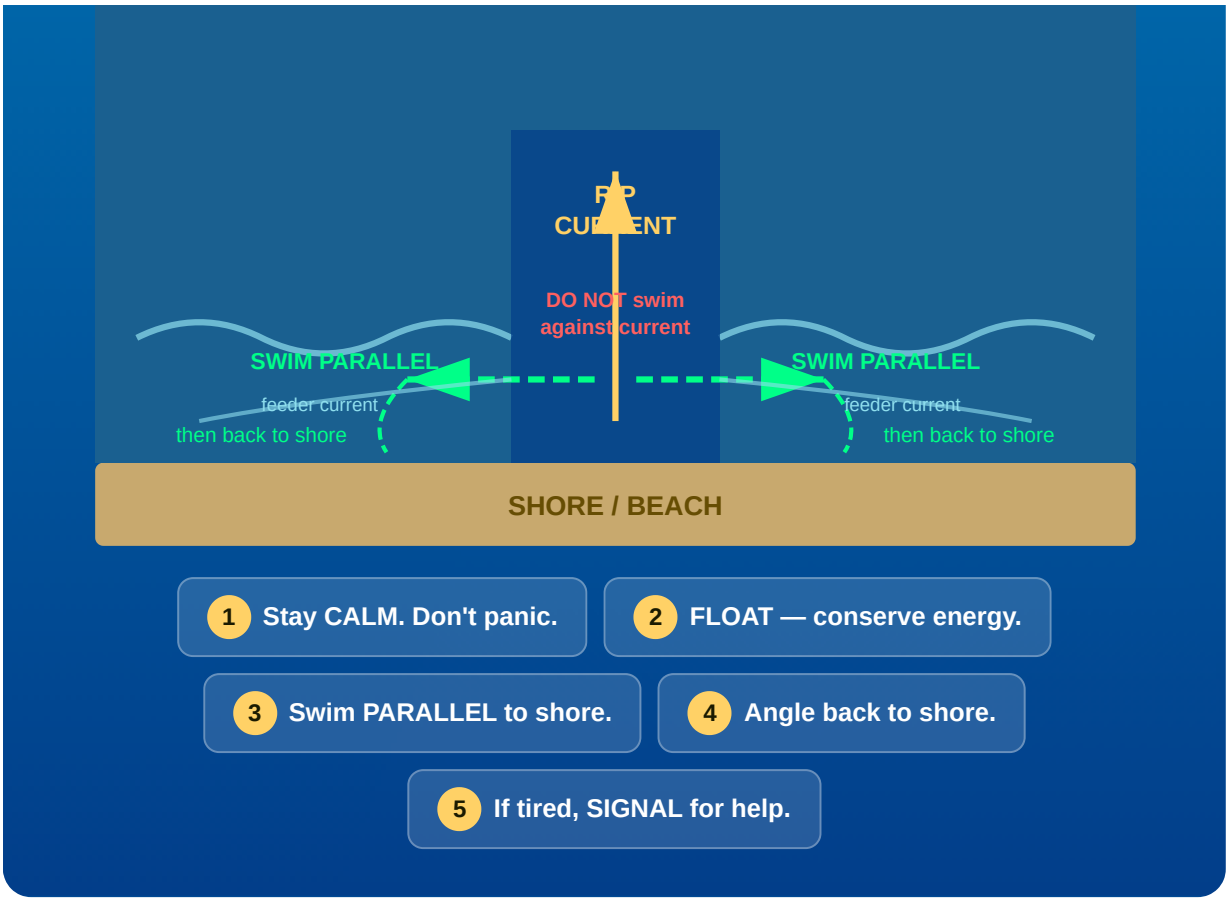
Activity 2.2 — Rip Currents: How to Escape

Individual · ~10 min

Rip currents are one of the leading causes of drowning at Australian beaches. They are fast-moving channels of water that flow from the shore out to sea. Understanding rip currents and how to escape them is a critical survival skill.



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3 MARKS

QUESTION 2.2A

Using the diagram above, describe in your own words the THREE steps you would take if caught in a rip current.

Step 1: _____

Step 2: _____

Step 3: _____

2 MARKS

QUESTION 2.2B

Why is it dangerous to try to swim directly against a rip current towards shore?

_____

_____

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📍 SCENARIO

Liam is a 14-year-old who went to the beach with friends on a hot summer day. They went to an unpatrolled beach. Liam swam out past where the others were standing and felt himself being pulled away from shore quickly. He began panicking and tried to sprint-swim directly back to the beach, but was getting more tired. His friends noticed and didn't know what to do.

4 MARKS

QUESTION 2.2C

Identify TWO mistakes Liam and his friends made, and explain what they should have done differently.

Mistake 1:

_____

They should have:

_____

_____

Mistake 2:

_____

They should have:

_____

_____

3 Emergency Response — DRS ABCD

📖 KEY KNOWLEDGE — THE DRS ABCD ACTION PLAN

- **D**anger — check for hazards before approaching
- **S**end — call 000 (triple zero) for emergency services
- **R**esponse — check if the person responds to you
- **A**irway — tilt head back, lift chin, check for obstruction

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- **B**reathing — look, listen, feel for up to 10 seconds
- **D**efibrillation — use AED if available; follow voice prompts
- **C**PR — 30 compressions, 2 breaths; repeat until help arrives
- THROW, DON'T GO — use reach or throw rescue to avoid becoming a victim

⚠️ **Critical Safety Rule — THROW, DON'T GO:** Most bystanders who enter dangerous water to help end up drowning themselves. Always attempt a reach or throw rescue first. Throw a rope, towel, kickboard, esky lid, or any floating object. Only enter water to rescue if you are trained to do so.

Activity 3.1 — DRS ABCD Memory Activity

Individual · ~5 min

Complete the DRS ABCD blocks below. Fill in the word that each letter stands for, then write a brief description of what to do at each step.

D	R	S	A	B	C	D
DANGER	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____

Now, in the table below, describe what you would DO at each step if you found someone unconscious face-down at the edge of a swimming pool.

Step	What I would do:
D	*e.g. Look around for any electricity, chemicals, or pool hazards before approaching...*
R	
S	
A	
B	
C	
D	

🎭 Activity 3.2 — Rescue Scenario Analysis

Pairs · ~12 min

📍 SCENARIO — THE RIVER ROPE SWING

Scene: It is a hot February day. You and your friends are at a popular (but unpatrolled) rope swing over a river. A 16-year-old you don't know swings out, lets go, and hits the water awkwardly. He sinks and doesn't come back up. His friends are watching from the bank. One of them jumps in to help and also starts struggling. You are standing on the bank. You have a towel, a rope attached to the swing, and your phone.

With a partner, discuss and then write your answers to the following questions:

2 MARKS

QUESTION 3.2A

What is your FIRST action and why? (Consider the 'throw, don't go' principle)

_____

_____

2 MARKS

QUESTION 3.2B

Why is it dangerous that the friend jumped in? What risk does this create?

_____

_____

3 MARKS

QUESTION 3.2C

If you successfully pull the unconscious teenager to the bank and he is not breathing, list the DRS ABCD steps you would take in order.

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

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4. _____ 5. _____ 6. _____

4 Making Safe Decisions Near Water

📖 KEY KNOWLEDGE — FACTORS THAT INCREASE RISK

- Peer pressure to swim in dangerous locations
- Cold water shock (involuntary gasp reflex)
- Swimming alone with no-one watching
- Ignoring warning signs and flags
- Overestimating your swimming ability
- Alcohol and drug use impairs judgment
- Jumping or diving without checking depth
- Inflatable toys in open water with offshore winds

🌊 LSV SWIMSAFE RULES — YOUR 5 RULES BEFORE YOU ENTER WATER

- 🪧 **Read Signs** — Always check warning signs, beach flags, and notices before entering any waterway
- 🦶 **Enter Feet First** — Never dive or jump into water you don't know — hidden rocks and shallow edges cause spinal injuries
- 📏 **Stay In Depth** — Only swim where you can comfortably stand, unless you are a confident, experienced swimmer
- 👫 **Swim With a Friend** — Never swim alone — drowning is silent, so having someone watch means someone can call for help
- 🙋 **Signal For Help** — Raise ONE arm if you're in trouble. Float, conserve energy, and keep signalling until help arrives

Source: Life Saving Victoria SwimSafe Program — https://lsv.com.au

🗺 Activity 4.0 — Hazard Mapping

Pairs · ~10 min

Below are three water environment types common in Victoria. For each one, list at least THREE specific hazards a swimmer might face. Rank each hazard H (High), M (Medium) or L (Low) risk.

Environment	Hazards (list at least 3)	Risk Level (H/M/L)	How to stay safe
🏖 **Patrolled Beach** (e.g. Torquay, Mornington Peninsula)	*1.* _____ *2.* _____ *3.* _____		
🏞 **River / Dam** (e.g. Yarra River, Lake Eildon)	*1.* _____ *2.* _____ *3.* _____		
🏊 **Pool** (public, school, or backyard)	*1.* _____ *2.* _____ *3.* _____		

2 MARKS

QUESTION 4.0A

Which environment above do you think is the MOST dangerous overall, and why? Use evidence from the Victorian drowning statistics to support your answer.

_____

_____

_____

Activity 4.1 — Risk vs. Benefit Analysis

Individual · ~10 min

For each of the following situations, identify the RISK and a SAFER ALTERNATIVE.

Situation	Risk(s)	Safer Alternative
Swimming at an unpatrolled beach at night on a dare from your friends		

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Using an inflatable lilo in the ocean on a windy day	
Jumping into a river from rocks without knowing the depth	
Going for a swim alone in a dam on a hot day	

3 MARKS

QUESTION 4.1A

Peer pressure is one of the key reasons young people take risks near water. Describe a strategy you could use to resist peer pressure to swim somewhere unsafe. Give a specific example of what you might say to your friends.

Strategy:

_____

What I could say:

_____

_____

_____

5 Victorian Inland Waterways, Cold Water & Rescue

Activity 5.1 — Cold Water Shock Research Task

Individual / pair · ~15 min

Victorian rivers, dams and lakes can be dangerously cold even on a hot summer day. Cold water shock is a physiological (body) response that happens when you suddenly enter cold water — it can incapacitate even strong swimmers.

💧 **Cold Water Shock Facts:** When you suddenly enter cold water (below about 15°C), your body triggers an involuntary gasp reflex, rapid breathing, increased heart rate and

blood pressure, and muscle weakness. These responses can cause you to inhale water and drown within minutes, even in shallow water. Alpine lakes such as Lake Eildon are fed by snowmelt and can remain below 15°C even in December and January.

2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.1A

Describe TWO physical effects cold water has on the body that can increase the risk of drowning.

1. _____

2. _____

2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.1B

What are TWO precautions you should take if you plan to swim or fish at an inland waterway (river, dam, lake) in Victoria?

1. _____

2. _____

2 MARKS

RESEARCH QUESTION 5.1C

Visit one of these sites and find ONE fact about Victorian inland waterway safety you didn't know before. Write the exact URL of the page you found it on.

🔗 **https://www.vic.gov.au/water-safety · https://lsv.com.au · https://paddle.org.au · https://www.parks.vic.gov.au**

Fact: _____

_____

Source URL:

_____

🪢 Activity 5.2 — Throw Rescue: Rank Your Equipment

Groups of 3–4 · ~8 min

Based on guidelines from the **Royal Life Saving Society Australia (RLSSA)**, the safest rescues keep YOU out of the water. Rank the items below from BEST (1) to WORST (5) as a rescue tool — and explain WHY in the third column.

Item	Rank (1–5)	Why? (explain the advantage or limitation)
🪢 Coiled rope / throw bag		
🛟 Life ring attached to the jetty		
🏊 Jumping in and swimming to them		
🪣 Throwing a pool noodle or esky lid		
👕 Holding out a towel or clothing from the bank		

Source: Royal Life Saving Society Australia rescue guidelines — https://www.royallifesaving.com.au

🍺 Activity 5.3 — Alcohol, Risk & Water

Individual · ~8 min

Alcohol is a significant factor in Victorian drowning deaths, particularly among adults. The scenario cards for this unit include alcohol-related scenarios. Use what you know to answer the questions below.

3 MARKS

QUESTION 5.3A

List THREE specific ways that alcohol affects the body that increase the risk of drowning.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.3B

A group of older teenagers are at a pool party celebrating. Some have been drinking. One decides to swim "to cool off." What are TWO specific risk factors that make this more dangerous than swimming sober?

1. _____

_____

2. _____

_____

🦴 Activity 5.4 — Diving, Shallow Water & Spinal Injury

Individual · ~12 min

⚠ KEY DATA — AUSTRALIAN DIVING & SPINAL INJURY STATISTICS

- Unsafe diving accounts for approximately **10%** of all spinal cord injuries and **20%** of quadriplegia cases in Australia *(AIHW Diving Injury Report)*
- **95%** of aquatic spinal injury patients are male — the highest-risk age group is children aged **10–14**

- **Two-thirds** of patients suffer permanent disability — the cervical spine (neck vertebrae) fractures on impact and the spinal cord cannot regenerate
- **Core prevention message: "Feet First, First Time, Every Time"** — always enter unknown water feet-first, and check depth on every visit regardless of prior experience
- A sandbank can form or shift between visits — tidal variation, drought, flooding, and sediment all change depth without warning

Sources: AIHW — aihw.gov.au · Royal Perth Hospital spinal injury review · RLSSA — royallifesaving.com.au

Case study	What happened	Key lesson
Terrigal Wharf NSW, 2025	A teenage boy dived from a wharf into water he believed was deep. Serious spinal injuries. Helicopter evacuation to hospital.	Wharves and jetties can sit over surprisingly shallow or tidal water. The height of the structure above tells you nothing about the depth below.
Torquay Front Beach Victoria, 2025	A teenage boy suffered a serious suspected spinal injury diving at a surf beach and was airlifted to hospital.	Surf beach sandbanks shift with every tide. Depth at any given point is constantly and unpredictably changing.
Bawley Beach Jetty NSW, 2024	A young man dived from a jetty he had used safely before. A sandbank had recently formed beneath the jumping spot between his visits.	False confidence from prior experience. "I've done it here before" is not a safety check. Always check depth every single visit.

2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.4A

The data shows that 95% of aquatic spinal injury patients are male and the highest-risk age group is 10–14 years. Explain why *you* might be in a higher-risk group for this type of injury, and what specific behaviour creates that risk.

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2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.4B

The Bawley Beach case (NSW 2024) shows a young man was seriously injured at a jetty he had used safely before — a sandbank had formed since his last visit. Explain why *"I've done it here before"* is a dangerous substitute for checking water depth.

2 MARKS

QUESTION 5.4C

Unsafe diving causes 10% of all spinal cord injuries in Australia. If you saw a friend about to dive into a river or dam at an unfamiliar location, design ONE specific, realistic action you could take — what would you say or do, and why?

6 Personal Action Plan, Community Response & Communication Campaign

💡 Activity 6.1 — Personal Water Safety Action Plan

Individual · ~12 min

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Using what you have learned in this workbook, create a personal water safety action plan. This should be realistic and specific to your own life.

6.1A — MY SWIMMING GOALS

What is one swimming or water safety skill you want to improve this year?

_____

_____

6.1B — MY SWIMSAFE COMMITMENT

Write down the FIVE LSV SwimSafe rules and circle the one you think is most important for you personally. Explain why in the space below.

Rule 1: _____

Rule 2: _____

Rule 3: _____

Rule 4: _____

Rule 5: _____

Most important for me because: _____

_____

6.1C — MY WATER SAFETY ACTION PLAN (CHOOSE ONE SCENARIO)

You are planning one of the following activities this summer. Choose the one most relevant to you. Complete a safety action plan for it.

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- ◯ 🏖 A beach day at Torquay / Mornington Peninsula
- ◯ 🏞 A river or lake trip (e.g. Yarra, Eildon)
- ◯ 🏊 A pool party at a friend's house
- ◯ 🛶 A kayaking / paddling trip (see paddle.org.au)

Plan Element	My Plan:
Hazards I might face	
Safety strategies I'll use	
Emergency plan (what if something goes wrong?)	
Equipment I'll bring	
Who I'll go with (buddy rule!)	

📣 Activity 6.2 — Water Safety Communication Campaign (Assessment Task)

`Individual · ~25 min · Summative`

Water safety is a community responsibility. Your task is to create a short water safety communication product for a specific audience. Choose ONE option below.

✅ **All options must include:** at least ONE accurate statistic with its source URL · a clear, specific safety message · a call to action (what you want the audience to DO)

Option A 🤳

Social media post for teens — Design 1–2 Instagram/TikTok slides for 13–17 year olds. Include a statistic, a visual element (drawn or described), and a hashtag/call to action.

Option B ✉️

Letter to a younger student — Write a 200-word letter to a Year 5 student explaining three things they must know about water safety in Victoria before summer.

Option C 🌐 Extension

Multilingual community fact sheet — Design a simple fact sheet explaining beach flags and Victorian waterway dangers for someone new to Australia.

Include at least 5 key points and 2 statistics.

Use this space to plan and draft your chosen option:

Option chosen: _____

Target audience: _____

Statistic I will use: _____

Source URL: _____

Key message: _____

Call to action: _____

Draft your campaign below (or attach a separate page / digital work):

Write or sketch your campaign content here...

✏️ Self-Assessment

Rate your confidence in each area after completing this workbook:

Skill/Knowledge Area	😕 Not confident	🙂 Getting there	😊 Confident
Identifying beach flags and their meanings	○	○	○
Knowing what to do if caught in a rip current	○	○	○

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Following DRS ABCD in an emergency	○	○	○
Recalling all 5 LSV SwimSafe rules	○	○	○
Making safe decisions near water	○	○	○
Understanding Victorian drowning statistics	○	○	○
Identifying hazards at different waterway types	○	○	○
Explaining the Throw, Don't Go rescue principle	○	○	○

One thing I want to learn more about:

Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0 · HPE · Year 7–8 · Safety Focus Area
Curriculum codes: VC2HP8P08 · VC2HP8P09 · VC2HP8P10 · VC2HP8M01

Life Saving Victoria: https://lsv.com.au
LSV Classroom Resources: https://lsv.com.au/toolkit
Victorian Curriculum: https://f10.vcaa.vic.edu.au
LSV Drowning Reports: https://lsv.com.au/what-we-do/research-advocacy
BeachSafe: https://beachsafe.org.au · St John Ambulance: https://www.stjohnvic.com.au
RLSSA Swim & Survive: https://www.drowningprevention.org.au/swimandsurvive
Paddle Australia: https://paddle.org.au · Parks Victoria: https://www.parks.vic.gov.au
Victorian Gov Water Safety: https://www.vic.gov.au/water-safety

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